

MW practical exam guidelines

A document developed by the study programme team to assist MW candidates preparing for the practical exam. Please note this document is purposefully not titled 'How to pass the MW practical exam', and it is not to be viewed in this light. Rather it is to be viewed as a starting point for candidates as they prepare to sit the Master of Wine practical exam. Please read this document in conjunction with the current examiners' report and note that the latter takes precedence over this document.

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EXAM TECHNIQUE – GENERAL SUGGESTIONS

While it is logical that the exam will feature a number of wines regarded as 'classics', it is important to note that any wine can be shown. There is no 'syllabus' of the wines to study.

A tidy paper indicates ordered and rigorous thought.

Examiners appreciate it when candidates write in short sentences, making an observation and then backing it up with a logical conclusion that is supported by evidence from the glass.

Candidates should normally state their answer at the beginning and then justify it. This makes it easier to see the logic of their argument and helps to ensure that the candidates provide a singular (and clearly stated) answer. However, sometimes it is best to leave it open and follow a logical argument through to the end. Sometimes the answer is not a single phrase that can be stated simply, particularly when considering winemaking, style or commercial position.

Examiners welcome candidates with an individual prose style. But banal, highly personal descriptions do not help the cause – for example, 'piggy nose'; 'rose water on a bed of phenolics'.

Similarly, a high level of slang is not appropriate. While sometimes amusing, it is equally often confusing, or simply vague, and rarely helps the candidate.

It is acceptable in this part of the exam to write in a simplistic, pared down style. Candidates who struggle with time may give relevant bullet point answers, which can give them good marks. However, excessive use of bullet points throughout the exam does not allow the candidate to clearly communicate critical thinking or to demonstrate confidence.

Abbreviations of the most common and conventional wine terms are acceptable in both the theory and practical exams. Candidates should not separately list the abbreviations they intend to use at the beginning of each paper or answer, but follow the normal practice of writing on the first occasion in any answer (for example) malolactic fermentation (MLF), before using that abbreviation for the rest of the answer.

Only use abbreviations that are universal within the context of wine. Abbreviations that are "unique" to the candidate can create confusion and frustrate the examiners.

Arguments for origin and grape variety should always be structured in such a way as to lead with the primary evidence that takes you to your conclusion, whether it is structure, aromatics or some other factor, followed up by evidence that supports your argument, and concluding with elements that are merely consistent with your identification.

When dealing with difficult-to-identify wines, such as a Gavi for example, candidates are not expected to be able to precisely spot these within a mixed bag. But they would be expected to at least consider two or three options appropriate to that kind of clean, elegant but fairly neutral white wine style.

With four wines to assess in a flight, there will typically be at least one that the examiners would consider as a 'banker' for the variety, or origin, in question.

It is important to use terminology and names that are relevant to the wine and area of its production. Thus, Syrah is preferred to Shiraz to refer to grapes grown in the Rhône.

Be specific – for example, be sure to identify the country as Spain and the region as Jerez rather than Sherry (the wine).

If asked for a region or grape variety, the answer should be complete. For example, not simply Pessac or Grüner. By contrast it is not necessary to use the title/answer Nuits St Georges, Côte de Nuits, Burgundy, France. Nuits St Georges is sufficient.

The term 'consistent with' has become very common. Candidates should use it with care, and only when they are sure that the logic of their tasting and their arguments are indeed consistent. Do note that the phrase (often tacked onto other arguments) 'flavour consistent' might sound logical, but in fact can rarely earn marks – if the candidate does not detail what that flavour is, then the argument has no weight. For instance, one will gain very few points by simply putting simply: 'Sauvignon Blanc; the aroma, structure and flavours all consistent with that variety.' You do need to be specific.

When describing acidity, terms like "medium plus" or "medium minus" are acceptable, but they should not be used consistently throughout the candidate's entire script. More descriptive terms, e.g. 'crisp', 'brisk' (acidity) or 'fine-grained', 'firm' (tannins), are suggestive of a more detailed understanding of the wine. Candidates also need to be careful that they are consistent (i.e. not describing it as crisp in one answer and moderate in another). Refer to the Tasting Lexicon document on the IMW website for some examples of descriptive terms. Note that these are only suggestions and do not limit the terminology that candidates can use.

Look at the allocation of marks and write length of answer accordingly. If there are only five marks for quality, for example, you can write a shorter and less detailed answer than one for 10 marks.

Break answers down into short paragraphs, particularly for the big questions. It makes them easier for the examiners to read and mark, and has more impact.

EXAM TECHNIQUE - FUNNELLING

The examiners understand that it is often necessary to consider a number of alternatives when attempting to identify origin or variety. The use of the 'funneling' technique is the best way to highlight where the candidate is going and therefore makes it easy to allocate marks.

However, candidates take this option to extremes and go through so many possibilities that they find themselves short of time to commit to detailed analysis for the final decision. The list of possible alternatives should be limited to three or four at most. Two or three possibilities may be even better if you're confident these are the most likely options, which will save you more time in the long run.

In some cases, funneling is not necessary. Flights from classic regions, for example, can give candidates the opportunity to use one clear observation across all wines in the flight to go straight to the region in question without an exhaustive consideration of other options.

Similarly, if faced with a 'banker', it is acceptable to jump straight in, without considering anything else (e.g. Fino Sherry, Gewürztraminer, New Zealand Sauvignon) if the candidate makes it clear why it is so startlingly obvious, and provides the appropriate proof. It shows impressive authority the examiners when the candidate is right, but can be a dangerous strategy when wrong!

Importantly, a funnelled answer should always end with a positive reason for the identification, rather than just being an elimination of the alternatives proposed at the start of the funnel.

QUESTIONS DEALING WITH VARIETY

Not all of the typical arguments (colour, acid, sugar etc) need to be addressed for a given wine. Instead, candidates should only use the most relevant evidence to help you efficiently prove your conclusion.

When grape variety follows a country of origin question, the final choice of grape variety depends, obviously, on the country of origin you previously selected. Examiners will give good marks for valid, clearly argued answers for incorrect grape varieties which were nevertheless correct for the (incorrect) origin. The candidate should in this case concentrate their analysis of grape varieties on the varieties appropriate to that region. You might mention other varieties, but only briefly and with some reference to the fact that they are not appropriate to the region.

Candidates need to be specific in describing colour, varietal character, alcohol, acidity, tannin (very important when it comes to fine wines), age, and oak treatment. Too often these components are described in overly broad terms that fail to support their argument. For example, 'pale hue, floral and apple aromatics and brisk acidity' can describe a young Riesling, an entry level Chenin or even an unoaked Chardonnay.

Where oak use is evident, extra marks will be gained if the type, vessel size, age, percent new and toasting of the oak are mentioned, when this can be gleaned from the glass.

QUESTIONS DEALING WITH ORIGIN

When faced with a question that asks for identification 'as closely as possible', candidates should drill down as far as they feel the quality of the wine will allow – the country, the region and/or appellation of production and, if relevant, the level of classification. If a wine is felt to be only of 'generic' quality, then a broader definition is perfectly acceptable. However, when the level of quality is clearly high, and the candidate has chosen a classic region, communal (or equivalent) identification would be expected and, if applicable, a level of classification.

Importantly, it is dangerous to be too prescriptive or ambitious in one's conclusions. Naming the specific 1er Cru vineyard within Gevrey Chambertin (without even a qualification such as 'typical of' or 'as often found in') can look very foolish when in fact the wine is a Mercurey. Similarly, candidates shouldn't mention producers as the substantial risk of being wrong far outweighs the very minor benefit of being right.

Unless country and region are asked for, candidates do not need, for example, to say St Julien, Bordeaux, France – St Julien is sufficient.

Candidates should try and find positive reasons why they are locating a wine, rather than entirely negative ones. That said, negative pointers can be useful, but they need to be used in balance with positive ones.

The evidence of a sense of 'terroir' can be used in some answers as an indication of an origin, but bear in mind that, although a sense of terroir is not a standalone attribute, it should be related to a specific place, and that place need not necessarily be Old World. A Chablis has a sense of Chablis, but a Barossa Shiraz also has a sense of place. And bear in mind that many wines from many different origins may have apparent 'minerality'; a sense of 'minerality' is therefore not, by itself, a confirmation of an origin.

Candidates can also use quality to assist argue for origin. However, they must be up to date. In Germany, QMP has been replaced with Prädikatswein. While this is a minor point, failing to make that distinction makes a candidate seem uninformed and less convincing – perhaps best to avoid such distinctions and stick to the clearly understood regulations such as Kabinett, Spätlese etc.

The examiners are aware that the Old World/New World differential is less clear than it used to be as each year goes by; as such, they are less and less useful terms for scoring points or for clear communication in the practical exam. Importantly, 'Old World/New World' are not synonyms for 'warm climate/cool climate'.

The 'cool climate region' or 'warm growing region' arguments are often badly used by candidates. For example, Alsace is often described as a 'cool climate region'. However, Alsace is not really a classic 'cool climate' area and, more importantly, the style of most Alsace wines is certainly not really one of a 'cool climate' region. Similarly, Hunter Valley is also often described as 'cool climate', when in fact the cool climate attributes of high acidity, low alcohol are mainly a result of early picking.

The examiners are open to the use of the term 'restrained fruit' but want candidates to know that it has become over-used as an argument for old world. There are occasions when the term is appropriate, but it should be used with caution.

QUESTIONS DEALING WITH VINTAGE/MATURITY

Bear in mind that candidates are encouraged never to double-guess the examiners, but there will almost always be an implication that, when asked to identify a vintage (as opposed to commenting on the state of maturity without reference to the actual year of production), that the vintage characteristics can be assessed accurately from the wines in question.

For classic regions, candidates are expected to know the characteristics of recent vintages, as well as the great vintages, especially when the question calls for a discussion on the weather's influence.

For maturity there needs to be an assessment of the current age of the wine, whether it is ready to drink now or would benefit from further ageing and, if so, how long it might improve for, and finally how long it is likely to hold before it declines. It is helpful to give a narrow bracket (two to three years old). However, if the candidate realises they are dealing with a classic area, consideration should be given to vintage options. Examiners are aware this is not a precise science, and personal tastes also come into the equation, but these questions provide a real opportunity for candidates to shine with their assessments.

When asked to describe 'relative maturity' the candidates are being asked to describe not only the ageing potential of the wines but also their actual age.

Potential development requires more of an understanding of the wine's quality and observable complexities, which must be interpreted in the light of each wine's state of maturity.

Candidates should think about a wine's capacity to develop and then potential to hold when at peak when considering its development curve.

QUESTIONS DEALING WITH QUALITY

Candidates must learn to 'get under the skin' of each wine when asked for a quality assessment. First impressions, an appreciation of aromatic intensity and an obvious oak influence, do not constitute by themselves an adequate assessment of quality.

It is useful to remember the acronym BLICC to ensure your quality note addresses sufficient components in the wine that contributing to its quality. Some people refer to BLICC (balance, length, integration, complexity and

concentration; or BLICCA including ageability) while others use BLIC (balance, length, intensity, complexity). Do note that the acronym itself should not be used in the answer; it is only a reminder to consider each key facet.

However, a quality note that simply says 'the wine has balance, length, intensity and complexity' is not an authoritative answer without further qualification in terms of what the wine is actually demonstrating. A more specific expression of what the wine really tastes like will get more credit.

Terms such as 'fine' and 'entry-level' can be used to endorse the candidate's assessment of quality. However, the use of these terms alone is often insufficient to clarify the candidate's view of the wine's status, not least because these terms have varying resonances in different markets. Similarly, "premium" is vague and needs to be further qualified.

Context of origin should always be considered, even if not specifically asked for. When referring to that context, candidates should use the appropriate hierarchy if the wine is from a European origin. If from a non-European origin, terms like single vineyard or "icon" can be helpful, or you can refer back to Europe – for instance "equivalent to 1er Cru".

By contrast, IGT and IGP are not useful quality indicators on their own. You should state whether you believe the wine to be an exceptional, average or modest example of that kind of general category.

For Port, the level of quality would normally be assessed with clear reference to style and classification (LBV, ruby etc.) along with age – all backed up by reference to what was in the glass, of course. This is true of many regions where the classification does attempt to reflect quality, such as Burgundy and Germany.

Candidates must make their quality assessments objectively. Finding a wine too oaky, for example, is frequently a personal judgment and not a reason to downgrade the quality; the same can be true of alcohol level. Importantly, candidates should not be dismissive about wines or wine styles which have large, successful commercial appeal (such as White Zinfandel).

When the candidate is required to set out what the expectation is of, for example, an entry level wine from whichever country the candidate had chosen as his answer, the candidate will get points if the answer is logical and correctly describes the quality even if the origin/variety were incorrectly identified earlier in the question.

In questions dealing with pairs of wine, candidates frequently lose marks by failing to clearly state which wine in the pair was of the higher quality. When a question asks you 'to compare and contrast relative quality', a consideration of key relative factors like complexity and maturity is needed.

Price is relevant (but not mandatory), as long as it accompanies a succinct analysis referring to the wine's intensity, structure, balance and so on. It requires a globally meaningful currency such as USD \$, GBP £ or EUR €. It is particularly helpful for entry-level wines up to and including those that you might consider 'reasonably' priced, or accessible to most wine consumers. It often makes little sense to list a price for collectible wines such as First Growth Bordeaux or Grand Cru Burgundy where the price can vary considerably based upon the producer or when and where it is sold. If a candidate never mentions monetary value in any of their quality answers they could still, theoretically, get full marks. The obvious point is that the candidate must make it abundantly clear what they think of the wine.

Candidates should normally state the level of quality up front, expressed as either the hierarchy of quality in a given region (where applicable) or in terms of market tier. A really successful quality argument invariably ends with a concluding statement about how good (or not) the wine is within the context of the quality level to which it has been ascribed.

QUESTIONS DEALING WITH STYLE

Commenting on 'the style of the wine' can be done in a number of ways, but in essence the candidate is being asked to describe what the wine tastes like and why it tastes like it does. Another way to think about it is to imagine a 'shelf talker' describing what the wine tastes like. The examiners' advice is for candidates to pretend they are describing the wine to an enthusiastic novice.

Marks on style are normally the easiest to pick up. They can be covered in one or two sentences and can often be entirely accurate even when your identification is some way off.

Answers need to be precise when using terminology such as 'oxidized'. For example, candidates often describe 20-year-old Tawny Port as 'oxidized'. It has been made in an oxidative style, but is certainly not fully 'oxidized'.

Imagine what could be written on the label and use these terms in your answer. For example: Brut, Reserva, Spätlese, Fino etc.

QUESTIONS DEALING WITH COMMERCIAL APPEAL/POSITIONING

Commercial appeal/positioning questions typically require a consideration of how a given wine/wines can be marketed most successfully, always referring to the evidence in the glass. They are all about putting the wine in either its global context or the context of a named local market, usually with some comment on the style of the wine, then discussing routes to market that resulted from this argument.

Various terms can be used on the MW Practical Exam, such as:

- Commercial appeal
- Commercial potential
- Commercial position
- Market appeal
- Market potential
- Market position

Commercial and Market mean the same thing and may be used interchangeably.

Appeal and potential mean essentially the same thing and refer to all aspects of selling the wine, such as:

- Who will buy the wine?
- Who will sell the wine?
- Where is the wine sold?
- When is the wine sold?
- How is the wine sold?

Position is perhaps more limited and refers to where the wine is sold (e.g. price and location), but also include its competitive set.

Bear in mind:

It is quite sufficient to say that this was an entry-level/mid-market/expensive style of wine, which then becomes part of the argument leading to the appropriate route to market. Candidates could include prices, but ideally only use widely applicable currencies such as US\$, GP £ or €.

It is helpful to mention the possible route to market. But it is only speculative to mention other issues that may have relevance to a marketing strategy, but cannot possibly be gleaned from tasting. An example: "Convenience from screwcap closure ... may catch eye of the adventurous consumer".

In market placement, it is acceptable to use such terminology as 'high street independents', but it must be logical.

On longer commercial questions, the best answers discuss not just style, food-matching and channel possibilities, but also bottle sizes, packaging, value for money, ways to attract younger drinkers. Candidates need to be clear that they cannot taste packaging and bottle size, but that these may be important market considerations.

Candidates should always consider both the specific commercial potential of the wine as well as the style that it represents. So, for instance, for Beaujolais, candidates will obviously refer to the lightness and freshness of the wine in question, and therefore its suitability for wine by the glass etc. But a good answer will also refer to the current state of Beaujolais domestically and on international markets; about which there is obviously plenty to say.

QUESTIONS DEALING WITH WINEMAKING

Consideration could be given to the following, always referring back to the glass:

- style – dry, RS, fortified, sparkling
- fruit ripeness and cleanliness/lack of rot
- picking date
- blend of varieties or single variety
- protective or oxidative techniques
- fermentation temperature
- fermentation period
- fermentation vessel
- carbonic maceration
- pump-over/punch down/other
- post-fermentation maceration
- MLF
- lees ageing
- batonnage
- oak regime – size, type, origin, age, toast level, percent new, time
- finishing – filtered, fined or unfiltered
- single year or blend of years
- maturation – non-oxidative bottle, oxidative - oak, inert, how long before release

Candidates must be aware that the examiners are also testing theoretical knowledge within the practical paper. However, they are never looking for an exhaustive explanation of the entire winemaking process, rather a set of logical conclusions based on what can be tasted in the glass, highlighting the key elements that influence the wine's style. For example, on a method of production question for Sherry, oxidative notes/lack thereof need to be discussed, especially with reference to ageing, as does the sweetness level and how it was achieved.

Following winemaking in a logical, chronological order from harvest (where appropriate) through to bottling not only helps candidates to remember the relevant process, but also helps the examiner follow the candidate's argument and allocate marks. Omission of a (winemaking) technique is just as valid as its use, for example, no new oak on the first wine in a pair but new oak on the second.

There is no need to state the apparently obvious. For instance, on a group of sparkling wines: 'CO₂ suggests a second fermentation'. Better to rather incorporate that comment into one which deals with how and where the bubbles got into the wine – second fermentation in bottle or tank, or carbonation.

There is no need to mention malo on a red wine unless the candidate is suggesting something interesting like the possibility of malo in barrel, or the prevention of malo. By contrast, it is obviously important to mention malo, or the lack thereof, in many white wine styles/varieties.

Candidates should avoid generic comments such as firm tannins = extended maceration that could be questioned. Firm tannins may simply be a characteristic of the grape variety. Tannin management is a complex and interesting area, candidates need to show that they have an understanding of the relevant methods that may have been employed, rather than resorting to shorthand cliché.

One phrase that frequently lets candidates down is 'temperature-controlled fermentation'. If the candidate is not sure of the temperature range, then such a vague comment may be the best they can offer. But, if they feel that the control of temperature was a key part of the winemaking under discussion, then it would be best to give specifics to make the point. Avoiding figures may give the impression the candidate is unsure of this aspect of winemaking.

In terms of new oak, it is highly difficult to taste a specific "percentage", however good candidates can offer an approximation based on evidence from the glass such as 10%, 25%, or 40-50%, etc. Conversely, candidates should also avoid the phrase 'some new oak', as 'some' is too vague; it could mean a little or a lot.

Many candidates are nervous about using the term 'oxidized' or 'oxidative' or 'volatile'. Such terms are appropriate to use when pertinent to the wine.

Timing of harvest should be mentioned if it is particularly relevant, for example late harvest, or botrytis, or particularly early.

Comments on vinification can include 'likely possibilities'. It is not always possible to be sure of every winemaking detail. One should not 'hedge' too much, but you can refer to issues and methods that are likely for the style, even if you are not certain. This might apply to: vine age; ripeness level at picking; acidification; chaptalization; de-stemming/whole-bunch fermentation; pump-over/punch-down/submerged cap; micro-oxygenation; carbonic maceration; fining and filtration, malo in barrel, etc. Candidates should pick out those methods that they think may well have been used, indicating what in their tasting leads them to that assumption.

It is of course arguable what we can and can't detect through tasting, and candidates should certainly be circumspect when referring to issues such as:

- handpicking versus machine (excluding botrytis etc.)
- use of screwcap
- foot-trodden grapes

Pre-fermentation cold-soak is one of several processes that may often seem 'likely', but it is rarely easy to justify it from your tasting. Do mention it where relevant, but don't refer to it every time, as seems to be the habit with some candidates!

The over-riding point here is that the candidate is welcome to speculate intelligently on 'likely' techniques that would be used to give that style, but should of course concentrate on the key factors that are really evident in the glass. Candidates should avoid talking about adjustments unless they are really obvious, which they seldom are. One exception would be fortified wine styles, where the alcohol levels are adjusted during the winemaking process.

UNITS

When considering alcohol and residual sugar, alcohol needs to be stated specifically (with a 0.5% margin of error) but residual sugar can be expressed as dry, off-dry, medium-sweet or fully-sweet unless the candidate is asked to be specific. That said, confident candidates who specify a number for residual sugar can gain valuable marks when correct.

Examiners realise that precise identification of sugar and alcohol is difficult at extreme highs and lows, and so leeway is given during the grading, unless the suggested levels are inconsistent legally or by practice – a Fino sherry described as 18% alcohol for example.

If a wine is dry, it is acceptable to write 'less than 5g/l'.

Hedging can go too far. For example, fermentation temperature 20-30C or lees contact 12-28 months is too broad.

LENIENCY

When wine styles are similar, the examiners will recognise this. For example, in many ways, Beaumes de Venise and Moscatel de Valencia are very similar. Even if Moscatel de Valencia is the correct answer, nearly full marks can be gained for the Beaumes de Venise option if answered well.

A mis-match (within a two pairs question) is not a fatal error and good marks can be earned, for example, when comparing the quality of the wines within pairs, even if they are the wrong pairs.

There is some leniency on whether candidates class varieties as semi-aromatic/neutral – for example, Pinot Blanc, Grüner Veltliner, Chenin Blanc.

TIPS FOR PREPARING FOR THE PRACTICAL EXAM

Please note this document is not to be viewed as the only way in which candidates should prepare for the practical exam. Rather, it is intended to provide an indication of what a candidate could include or consider when developing a strategy. Every candidate, having different strengths and weaknesses, should develop his or her own unique strategy.

Bear in mind that the most recent examiners' report takes precedence over all other documents.

If you have any questions or receive conflicting advice from different MWs, never hesitate to contact the IMW office who will direct your inquiry to the examination team, or ask the examiners directly when they attend education seminars and/or course days.

Devise your strategy

You must be working to an honest strategy, based on an appraisal of your strengths and weaknesses, focusing on redressing those weaknesses.

It's human nature: all too often when we prepare ourselves for a challenge, we practise or begin with those tasks we enjoy and find easy when we should be tackling those that are difficult. It is easy to get better at things we are good at, and hard to get better at things we dislike doing, but exams comprise both.

The practical papers are as much about theoretical knowledge, communication and time management as they are about tasting skill. Your strategy for preparing for these elements should acknowledge that.

Your strategy for preparing for the practical (and theory) should also consider mental and psychological preparation. Confidence and enjoyment are powerful psychological success factors. Some people do well with the support system(s) that exists around them – family, friends, colleagues. Others may need professional advice from a life coach or a sports psychologist.

Candidates do best in the exam when they enjoy it and are confident. It's so important to have the authority of tone that comes from the confidence that you're a master of your subject (versus the bravado of the non-confident). Devise a strategy that gets you to that point.

Build your theoretical knowledge

As an MW candidate, you are expected to already have considerable theoretical knowledge about the world's grapes and wines. But it can be useful to review this knowledge, and 'plug the gaps' that your review highlights.

Consider compiling decision trees or simple lists of the grape varieties you could expect to see in the exam and research where these are grown, how they are made, what distinguishes them from the same variety/varieties grown elsewhere in the world, what quality levels do they attain, and what factors contribute to this quality (soils, altitude, aspect, rainfall etc.).

So, for chardonnay, a starting point might be to start with Chablis, Burgundy and other origins in France, before expanding your tree to include chardonnays from other major producing countries in both hemispheres. Don't forget to include the simpler, mass-market examples. You will be considering carefully the similarities and differences between all the key styles of chardonnay.

You'd follow the same approach for the other major grapes bottled as single varieties as well as for the world's major blends (red and white), its sparkling wines, its sweet wines, its rosé wines and its fortified wines. Remember, it is very important to know the defining sugar and alcohol levels for sparkling, sweet and fortified wines as well as how that sweetness, level of fortification or bubbles came about.

It's also necessary to follow a similar approach to understanding the impact of vintages in classic areas. This includes the obvious like Bordeaux, Burgundy, Champagne and Port but also extends to German Riesling, Barolo, Chianti, Rioja and new world classics like New Zealand Sauvignon Blanc, Sonoma Chardonnay, South Australian Shiraz etc.

Hone your tasting skills

Of course, to truly understand a wine or wine style, you need to taste it. This means – if you cannot afford to buy every wine you want to taste, and who can – you need to create as many opportunities for yourself as you can to taste and learn.

In addition to meeting regularly with other MW candidates to taste and practice writing answers you can:

- Join a local wine tasting group or start your own
- Attend the tastings organised by MWs, or other experts, specifically for MW students – see the MW website for a list.
- PAMS exercises are good opportunities to do some in-depth research on wine styles with which you may be unfamiliar. All too often, PAMS markers see candidates guessing incorrectly at levels of alcohol, acidity, aromatics, etc. Unless you are very confident, you should find relevant technical sheets to help you, but best of all, go out and buy examples and taste.
- Attend tastings held at wine shops or restaurants and hotels.
- Visit trade shows (but have a plan, don't taste at random).
- Attend the tastings organised by the generic bodies.
- Sign up as a judge or an associate judge at wine competitions.
- Visit the wine regions and taste in situ with the winemakers.
- Ask a local wine magazine or wine columnist if you may join them for tastings.

Identify collectors living near to you and ask if they'd mind sharing their knowledge (and their cellar) with you. Attend the tastings organised by MWs or other experts (see the MW web site for a list).

It's very important that you don't limit your tasting to the highest quality wines; you must taste across the quality spectrum. The ability to distinguish between quality levels within a similar style is always tested in the exam.

Exercise your weaknesses rather than your strengths. Compare wines which you tend to mix up: Oloroso versus Madeira, Banyuls versus Ruby Port, Pinot Gris versus Riesling. Taste them sighted and note the differences. Then taste them blind again and again, until they no longer confuse you.

Be 'honest' in important, different ways. There's value in asking yourself questions about your tasting and being really honest – for example, 'how good do I REALLY believe this wine is? Am I utterly convinced it's Vintage Champagne?' On a broader scale, it's worth being honest in about yourself in general. 'Am I truly ready to sit this exam?' If you're really ready, you should be confident in your judgement as to whether that wine is Vintage or NV. The 'honesty check' is a safety measure to prevent you talking yourself into something that's wrong.

Improve your communication skills and time management

You will have noticed, when you reviewed the past exam papers on the website, that the essence of the questions asked haven't change too much over the years, although the precise wording does vary each time.

You should prepare yourself to answer questions quickly and precisely about variety, origin, quality, maturity etc. You don't always need to practise using actual wine. You can write 'dry' tasting notes while on an airplane, train or waiting for an appointment. It will help you find the rhythm to communicate clearly and quickly.

When it comes to time management, you must get used to answering exam papers under exam conditions. In each paper, there are 12 wines, 300 marks and 135 minutes, which breaks down to 25 marks and 11 minutes per wine.

Successful candidates tell of attacking a flight of four wines every morning (at 11 minutes a wine, that's less than an hour out of your day). Print out past exam papers and give your partner, or a friend, a budget. Let them purchase similar wines to those presented in the exam and set up these tastings for you. This doesn't mean they have to be with you each day. They can decant them into empty bottles, or simply wrap them in paper with capsules removed, and label them, allocating them to a question. So you'll know that T1, T2 and T3 along with question T indicates you should taste these three T wines and answer question T on Tuesday'; and so on.

Most successful candidates also sit a 12-wine paper at least twice a month, either with their MW study group or using wines that someone has set up for you.

The important thing is to practice discipline. Calculate how much time to spend tasting a wine and making your notes. So it might well be two minutes a wine; six minutes for a flight of three; eight minutes for four. When time is up, push the glasses away and begin writing. When your 9 minutes is up for the first wine, start on wine two

regardless of whether you've completed the answer or not. Do this again and again, until you can finish in the allotted time.

It can also be useful to regularly tackle a 12-wine exam under timed conditions – without the wines. If you know you use three minutes a wine to taste, then subtract this 36 minutes from your time allowance and just write the answers as if you had tasted the wines. This gets you familiar with the timing but also the terminology you are going to use. You don't want to be in the exam flailing around for a word to describe acidity in Vouvray; instead you're familiar with your own wine vocabulary and you are going to use the word 'bracing'.

Never look for the 25th point out of 25. Perfection takes too much time. Go on to the next answer and finish the paper and collect the easier points.

You should always write the shortest and fastest answers about wines you are most confident about. This will leave you additional time to address the wines you struggle to recognize; it's there that you need it. If you cannot identify the origin and variety (usually asked first in the question) you can start with writing the quality/style/commercial appeal and collect all the points there – and then go on to the top.

Finally to say that getting feedback, and making the most of that feedback, is critical to making progress.

- Try swapping papers with another MW candidate to mark, and concentrating particularly on how clearly they communicated, rather than simply whether they were right or wrong.
- Don't be defensive about criticism. Even if you don't fully agree with a point being made about your work, try and be as self-critical as possible and consider how your answer could have been improved. The marker may, indeed, have been harsh, or simplistic in their response. But that is how they read what you wrote. Your job is to convince anyone who is considering your argument, whether they are the Practical Exam Chair or a PAMS marker doing that job for the first time.
- Look up the relevant tech sheets after doing a blind tasting. Keep in mind those sheets may not be 100% accurate, but be very careful to identify where your tasting was accurate or inaccurate, and concentrate on areas where you know you are weak.
- Non-native speakers might feel their limited vocabulary as a disadvantage but look at it from another side: you lack the vocabulary to waffle, so you can write more precise notes. You should also be aware that examiners know when English is not your primary language; leniency can be given when marking. However, you should certainly share practice papers with your mentor or anyone else willing to read them, and ask for constructive feedback on the clarity of your communication.